UNITED STATES OF AMERICA
BEFORE THE
FEDERAL ENERGY REGULATORY COMMISSION

Interconnection of Large Loads to the Interstate Transmission System	))))	**Docket No. RM26-4-000**

COMMENTS OF LONGROAD ENERGY HOLDINGS, LLC TO ADOPT OPEN ACCESS 2.0

Longroad Energy Holdings, LLC ("Longroad") commends the U.S. Department of Energy ("DOE") and the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission ("Commission" or "FERC") for opening this rulemaking.[1] As Chairman Swett emphasized at the November 20, 2025 Open Meeting, "It is crucial to economic and national security that we win the artificial intelligence data race for our country so that American data does not go abroad."[2] Her "priority as Chairman is to ensure that our country can connect and power data centers as quickly and as durably as possible."[3]

This docket presents the opportunity to think big about existing planning processes and make holistic changes to address the inefficiencies that presently stifle the interconnection of large load as well as the generation and transmission needed to serve that load. Continued leadership from the DOE and the Commission will be needed to effectively optimize transmission planning, large load interconnection and generation interconnection. The integration of these three activities is essential to create a streamlined process for the interconnection of large loads that will benefit national security, utility customers and the economy. Simply creating a standalone large load interconnection process

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1 *Interconnection of Large Loads to the Interstate Transmission System*, Docket No. RM26-4-000, Notice Inviting Comments (Oct. 27, 2025); *Interconnection of Large Loads to the Interstate Transmission System*, Docket No. RM26-4-000, Advanced Notice of Proposed Rulemaking (Oct. 23, 2025) ("ANOPR").

2 Video of November 20, 2025 Commission Meeting at 5:57-6:08 (available at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_Cxq0gORq8c&embeds_referring_euri=https%3A%2F%2Fwww.ferc.gov%2F&source_ve_path=OTY3MTQ).

3 *Id.* at 6:14-22.

for public utility transmission providers to implement alongside the current uncoordinated generation queue and transmission planning processes will not provide the required speed and cost efficiencies. These comments address the need for reform – Open Access 2.0 – that will require public utility transmission providers to jointly plan transmission, generation and load in a synchronized and coordinated fashion. Open Access 2.0 is needed to ensure that the United States remains energy and data center dominant.

I. Description of Longroad Energy Holdings, LLC

Longroad is an energy developer focused on the development, ownership and operation of generation and energy storage projects throughout North America. Longroad has developed or acquired 6.9 gigawatts ("GW") of generation projects, owns approximately 5.1 GW of operational generation projects across the United States and provides asset management services for another 5.4 GW on behalf of third parties. Longroad has a development pipeline of generation and storage projects that totals more than 30 GW with 3.2 GW of projects positioned to close financing by the end of 2026. Longroad has a number of large load interconnection positions in several markets across the United States and is actively pursuing additional sites.

II. Comments

A. The Existing Planning And Interconnection Processes Are Unnecessarily Costly And Inefficient.

There are two main impediments to quickly interconnect large loads: a lack of generation and a lack of transmission capacity. The current practices that public utility transmission providers employ will not solve those problems because generation interconnection and transmission planning are siloed.

The premise of the ANOPR – standardization of the process to interconnect large load to the transmission system – is similar to the standardization that the Commission put in place for generation interconnection over 20 years ago when it saw the need to support the development of competitive generation. However, today, we face a very different paradigm. Generation queues are backlogged. Although public utility transmission providers are catching up, particularly with the aid of Order No. 2023 reforms, our aging transmission infrastructure is in need of significant supplement. Large loads are facing difficulty getting interconnected in a timely and cost-effective manner and risk facing queue congestion issues that have plagued the generator interconnection process. The ANOPR seeks to add a separate large load interconnection process that risks creating discord with the existing generation and transmission processes which, at present, are insufficiently coordinated. This is a natural progression of how Order No. 888 (transmission) and then Order No. 2003 (generation) have been assimilated to public utility transmission provider processes. But if the goal is to interconnect load in a sustainable fashion, we need a more cohesive model.

Longroad is concerned that merely grafting on a separate load interconnection process that is addressed in isolation will only exacerbate the inefficiencies that currently exist in the siloed generation and transmission planning processes. The ANOPR explains, "United States electricity demand is expected to grow at an extraordinary pace, due, in large part, to the rapid growth of large loads."[4] To meet this demand, the nation needs fully integrated processes for transmission planning, generation interconnection and large load interconnection. Today, that integration does not exist at the scale needed to provide the electricity our national security and economy require.

Currently, different models and assumptions within and outside of regional transmission organizations ("RTOs") are used for generation and transmission planning. This fractionated nature and use of different modeling assumptions are causing, in some instances, transmission overbuild or

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4 ANOPR at Section II.A.

piecemeal transmission that is not efficiently optimized. Upgrade costs for generation that are unnecessarily costly have prevented generation from being built, which delays service to large loads. To the extent large load is also assessed unnecessarily costly network upgrades, load too may withdraw undermining the impetus for the ANOPR, which is to facilitate the rapid interconnection of data centers for national security. The fractured processes have also resulted in situations where NRIS studies have become impossible to solve, rendering them meaningless in some planning regions because many projects with interconnection agreements do not have a viable development path (offtake) and yet are still consuming NRIS capacity. Longroad is concerned that a piecemeal ANOPR that does not holistically look at the broader processes may become plagued with the same conditions that are currently at play. That is not a just and reasonable result. That will not "ensure that our country can connect and power data centers as quickly and as durably as possible."[5]

Interconnection and transmission planning need dramatic structural reforms. The national security imperative to bring data centers and the generation that serve them online quicker underscores the need for the FERC to step back, map out how each RTO and utility in a non-RTO region plans for the future and build a record that will help us get to Open Access 2.0. If the status quo remains, Longroad is concerned any rule that comes from this ANOPR will only add a further process that risks being implemented in a conflicting, fractionated manner: transmission planning will use certain modeling inputs, as occurs today; load will be studied with different modeling inputs; and generation will be studied with still different modeling inputs. There will be no cohesion or synergy among these processes that are inherently connected and seek to achieve the same goal: serve the customer (load) at the lowest possible cost.

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[5] Video of November 20, 2025 Commission Meeting at 6:14-22 (available at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_Cxq0gORq8c&embeds_referring_euri=https%3A%2F%2Fwww.ferc.gov%2F&source_ve_path=OTY3MTQ).

Open Access 2.0 would take the nation to the next level where transmission planning, generator interconnection and large load interconnection are modeled the same and in a coordinated, cohesive fashion.

This can be done with leadership from the Commission. Longroad acknowledges this is not easy. But that was the case when the Commission forged Order No. 888. It took hard work to break the historical paradigm that created rules for Open Access. Yet, the fruit has been tremendous, as can be seen from the proportion of nationwide generation that is independently owned and operated and which is developed through competitive processes and/or at risk to market forces. Competition is flourishing, which benefits the consumer. Large load interconnection can receive a similar benefit with hard work that creates Open Access 2.0.

What Longroad proposes is not novel. The Commission identified this same need just a few years ago in its Order No. 1920 process. In the notice of proposed rulemaking, the Commission explained that it sought to create "Proactive, forward-looking transmission planning that considers evolving supply and demand conditions more comprehensively" because "there may be a need for better coordination between the regional transmission planning and cost allocation and generator interconnection processes."[6] The Commission stated plainly that, "by upgrading the transmission system in a piecemeal fashion through the generator interconnection process, the current transmission planning paradigm . . . can present a potential barrier to entry for new generation resources that might otherwise be economic if not for the cost of interconnection-related network upgrades."[7] These positions echoed the earlier advanced notice of proposed rulemaking that found "the generator

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6 *Building for the Future Through Electric Regional Transmission Planning and Cost Allocation and Generator Interconnection*, Notice of Proposed Rulemaking, 179 FERC ¶ 61,028 at PP 28, 154 (2022).

7 *Id.* at P 165.

interconnection process appears to be the principal means by which infrastructure is built to accommodate new generators."[8] Chairman Glick and Commissioner Clements explained that "we are concerned that existing regional transmission planning processes may be siloed, fragmented, and not sufficiently forward-looking, such that transmission facilities are being developed through a piecemeal approach."[9] However, the Order No. 1920 process began almost five years ago before the impact and importance of large loads were apparent and, unfortunately, these issues were not addressed. The concepts and concerns the Commission raised then are still true today. Large load interconnection grafted onto the current system is not going to achieve energy and data center security.

In its thirteenth principle for reform, the ANOPR explains that "there must be a plan to implement these proposed reforms" and seeks "comment on appropriate transition plans . . . ."[10] Longroad respectfully submits that, in many ways, the concepts presented in the ANOPR should be viewed as *the transition process* and not the final product. The ANOPR provides concepts that are the basis to ensure that large load has non-discriminatory access to the transmission grid and at just and reasonable rates, terms and conditions. This will improve the pathway for the interconnection of large loads. Although the details of how that will occur still need to be flushed out, such as what an RTO or utility will study and how that will be done in concert with existing transmission and generation study processes, the concepts are there and can be a quick fix in the short-term because they graft onto the current Open Access implementation. However, that should not be the end. Longroad respectfully submits the Commission should follow through with what it initiated in the

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8 *Building for the Future Through Electric Regional Transmission Planning and Cost Allocation and Generator Interconnection*, Advanced Notice of Proposed Rulemaking, 176 FERC ¶ 61,024 at P 32 (2021).

9 *Id.* (Glick and Clements Concurrence at P 8).

10 ANOPR at P 30.

early stage of the Order No. 1920 process and provide means for comments to be submitted that address the gaps that exists in the RTO and utility processes and propose solutions. Indeed, there are best practices that should be explored such as the ERCOT "Connect and Manage" process that expedites the interconnection of new generation resources by prioritizing local grid connections and managing broader system impacts in real-time operations. During periods of grid stress, transmission providers direct the dispatch of available generation. Inclusion of options allowing large loads to dispatch their energy consumption can add valuable tools to the grid operator's toolbox. Another option might be:

(1) Transmission Provider identifies energy zones or areas of high interest to build generation and large load, and developers would put up financial milestones to confirm the interest is serious;

(2) Transmission Provider determines transmission needs by sub-region or area to support the generation and large load need;

(3) Transmission Provider makes this part of its larger transmission planning process in which other reliability and economic needs are addressed; and

(4) Transmission Provider allocates costs by area or subregion, with generation interconnection customers paying for reliability network upgrades and load serving entities assigned the cost for deliverability network upgrades.

Under the current construct, transmission planning and development lags behind the needs of large load and the generation required to serve large loads. In the traditional process, utilities perform economic forecasts to build out transmission to meet future needs, but the result cannot accommodate the needs of large load interconnections. If there are development zones, there will be increased clarity on the areas for development and remote network upgrade transmission costs might be allocatable to generators and large loads seeking to develop in those zones. However, Longroad is highly concerned that reliance on energy zones could lead to rampant land speculation and invites other ideas to enhance transmission capacity without creating excessive speculative behavior or shifting speculative behavior from an interconnection queue to a land rush.

Other solutions will emerge as the discussion unfolds. From that, the Commission would adopt a new set of pro forma requirements – Open Access 2.0 – that mandate and delineate holistic load, generation and transmission planning.

B. The Reform Principles – For A Transition To Open Access 2.0.

1. *Load and Generation Must Be Studied Together Based On The Amount Of Injection And/Or Withdrawal Rights Requested (Third Reform Principle)*.

This reform can help to address the failures of the current interconnection process for both generation and large load that is rife with study delays and overbuilding or inefficient build that creates further delay, unnecessary cost and at times withdrawals. The Commission has received comments that explain how load and generation can be synced, allowing both generation and load to connect without waiting for transmission build to support the relationship.[11] If the generation is in close geographic proximity to the load, such as two busses away, network upgrades may not be needed. If the generation is a bit farther away, the tie to specific load (providing a sure sink) will also reduce the need for network upgrades. Both scenarios would allow for fast interconnection of generation and load because there is no transmission addition impediment. However, the current study processes do not allow for this. Further, the current systems use a static base case that is often stale by the time the generation or load is studied. The base case should be updated for all known and confirmed load, which will minimize piecemeal build – at least until Open Access 2.0 principles are adopted.

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[11] *Meeting the Challenge of Resource Adequacy in Regional Transmission Organization and Independent System Operator Regions*, Docket No. AD25-7, Comments of Eolian, LP Recommending that the Commission Issue a Show Cause Order at 6-8, 13-14 (July 7, 2025).

2. *Cost Responsibility For Network Upgrades (Eighth Reform Principle)*.

The ANOPR proposes that load and generation facilities should be responsible for 100% of the cost of network upgrades they are assigned through the interconnection studies.[12] However, the ANOPR also seeks comment on whether "such cost should be offset through a crediting mechanism."[13] Longroad urges the Commission to adopt a crediting mechanism. Load and generation would provide backstop security or funds to enable the interconnecting transmission owner to build any required network upgrades following what the Commission adopted in Order No. 2003, and then the load and generation would be reimbursed via credits or cash. The legality of the ANOPR is premised on the notion that load is connecting to transmission in interstate commerce. In Order No. 2003, the Commission provided for reimbursement because the network upgrades are integrated into the larger transmission grid from which transmission customers and load benefit. That integrated nature has been cast aside with deviations that have been allowed in certain RTO markets. A byproduct has been undermining the beneficiary pays concept. Transmission customers and load clearly benefit as the Commission found in Order No. 2003 and related cases because of the integrated nature of the network upgrades. Reimbursement effectuates that reality. At the very least, if the Commission views some benefit accruing to load or generation, then a shared cost responsibility among all beneficiaries should be considered.

Another byproduct of the Commission's move away from the Order No. 2003 reimbursement paradigm and moving to participant funding has been removal of the incentive for the public utility transmission provider to optimize transmission planning. The public utility transmission provider does not roll the cost into rate base and earn a rate of return, so there is no incentive to optimize what

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12 ANOPR at P 25.

13 *Id.*

is foisted on generation and load. If the public utility transmission provider was held accountable for what is rolled into rate base, it would optimize solutions to connect generation and load. Thus, today, in RTO markets that cover significant portions of the United States, piecemeal transmission solutions emerge through generation interconnection and load interconnection. As noted above, the Commission has recognized this is not a healthy paradigm. The paradigm should change.[14] Of course, to the extent the Commission adopts holistic Open Access 2.0 pro forma reforms, this issue may be moot.

3. *Developers Must Have The Option To Build (Ninth Reform Principle).*

The option to build is a staple of Commission policy, and it should be allowed for large load interconnections. Large load developers should not be held back by transmission owner construction delays and cost. Comments in Docket No. AD25-7 confirmed the need for speed, consistent with a premise of the ANOPR. Lanny Nickell, President and CEO of SPP, stated, bringing "complex and long-duration [generation and energy storage] projects online more quickly is critical."[15] Stacey Burbure, American Electric Power, Senior Vice President of Transmission Business Development and Joint Ventures, explained that we need "speed and flexibility" to address these issues.[16] Similarly, when asked by the Commissioner Rosner what is needed, Commissioner Patrick

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[14] This would also solve the Self-Funding problem that the Commission has preliminarily found unduly discriminatory, preferential and not just and reasonable, and which was remanded to the Commission years ago by the DC Circuit to address the apparent discriminatory nature of Self-Funding. *Midcontinent Indep. Sys. Operator, Inc., et. al.*, 187 FERC ¶ 61,170 at PP 1-2, 18 (2024) (Order to Show Cause issued to MISO, PJM, SPP and ISO-NE regarding the justness and reasonableness of the TO Initial Funding mechanism). If there is a crediting mechanism with the cost of network upgrades rolled into transmission rate base, the public utility transmission provider earns a rate of return, consistent with what the Commission required in Order No. 2003, and the premise for Self-Funding vanishes.

[15] *Meeting the Challenge of Resource Adequacy in Regional Transmission Organization and Independent System Operator Region*, AD25-7-000, Pre-Filed Statement of Lanny Nickell, President and CEO, Southwest Power Pool at 5 (May 27, 2025) (available at https://www.ferc.gov/media/lanny-nickell-spp-president-and-ceo).

[16] *Meeting the Challenge of Resource Adequacy in Regional Transmission Organization and Independent System Operator Regions*, Docket No. AD25-7, Technical Conference Transcript at 551:5-6 (June 5, 2025).

O'Connell of the New Mexico Public Regulatory Commission stated that "speed is the biggest thing."[17] Casey Cathey, Vice President of Engineering at SPP, reinforced this position, explaining that "we need speed."[18] National security interests cannot be held hostage to public utility transmission provider delays. If large load can build the "stand-alone" connection facilities faster and at a lower cost than the interconnecting utility, the national security need and fairness to the consumer dictate that it must be allowed.

III. Conclusion

Longroad again commends the DOE and the FERC for initiating this important proceeding. Longroad urges the FERC to take advantage of this opportunity to address inefficiencies that have persisted for far too long. Reform that requires holistic and unified planning of transmission, generation and load, *i.e.*, Open Access 2.0, will best ensure that the national security and economic interests of our country are achieved. Simply grafting load interconnection to the existing process is not in the national or public interest.

Respectfully submitted,

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November 21, 2025

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[17] *Id.* at 548:12-15.

[18] *Id.* at 549:18-19.

CERTIFICATE OF SERVICE

I hereby certify that I have this day served a copy of the foregoing document on the persons designated on the official service list compiled by the Secretary in this proceeding.

Dated at Washington, D.C. this 21st day of November 2025.

/s/ *Shane Early*
Shane Early